

BEST ADVICE

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US-based Coursera is a leading edtech platform that has partnerships with global institutions



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“Don’t let a unique chance slip by”

What was the problem you were grappling with?

In 1996, Bill Sharpe, a Nobel Prize winner, offered me a job to write the business plan for a fintech company he wanted to start. By then, I had accepted an offer from McKinsey. Choosing to turn down McKinsey to join a brand new start-up, with no employees, was a huge decision. I had to think hard about this choice: the known prestige of McKinsey versus the adventurous potential of starting something new.

Whom did you approach for advice and why?

I turned to my wife for advice. Knowing her deep love for me and understanding of my dreams, I trusted her opinion wholeheartedly. We’re in this together, and her ‘yes’ is crucial for my big career moves. She needs to be completely in agreement in any professional decisions I make.

What was the advice you received?

She said, ‘Jeff, this is a unique chance—a once-in-a-lifetime shot to start a company with a Nobel laureate. McKinsey is great and successful, sure, but they’ll be fine without you. You can’t let this chance slip by.’ She always knew I wanted to be an entrepreneur, and not just have a tech job. Here I had the opportunity to develop technology that helps people achieve retirement security.

How effective was it in resolving the problem?

Hearing her say it, I felt sure and confident. Her belief in me made it clear: starting Financial Engines with Bill Sharpe was the right move. Her constant support has been a light guiding me, making me even more determined and hopeful about this incredible journey.

The life of an entrepreneur and a tech company CEO is always busy and unpredictable. Your spouse is on this roller coaster with you. It matters so much that the people you live with and share your life with are aligned, supportive and stand with you. **BT**

—TEAM BT

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